Forum:	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO)
Issue:	Addressing the exclusion of scientific theories from national education curricula due to cultural and ideological factors
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Position:	President

Personal Introduction

Dear Delegates,

My name is Emmanuela Tzokas and I'm a 10th-grade student at Costeas Geitonas School (CGS). Initially, I would like to express my excitement to serve as the President of UNESCO at this year's MOMUN.

During the time I have spent at MUN conferences, I have come to realise that they are more than just an extracurricular activity offered by schools. MUN has been instrumental in my academic and personal development and I can't imagine where I'd be without it. One of the main reasons I started MUN was as a way to face my fear of public speaking, and to be perfectly honest, I have yet to achieve that goal. But throughout the process, I have cultivated an understanding of global politics and humanitarian issues, broadened my horizons, and pushed myself out of my comfort zone.

I hope that you find this guide to be helpful and will be able to use it to create unique and inventive resolutions. If you have any questions or difficulties in understanding the topic, you can email me at emmtzokas@gmail.com.

I look forward to meeting you all in person!

Best regards,

Emmanuela Tzokas

Introduction

Ever since the integration of scientific theories into school curricula, there has been an unsettling response from concerned citizens or governments to remove certain theories for cultural and ideological reasons. This has contributed to the perception that religious, cultural or personal beliefs cannot coexist with scientific facts.

While many nations and respected organisations acknowledge and respect both perspectives, as the world constantly evolves and changes drastically, science education has become imperative and a lack of scientific knowledge or misconceptions about the topic could severely damage an individual's professional and academic future. Although recommendations have been put into place by the United Nations, national organisations and the Council of Europe, implementation remains uneven. Even though the topic is mainly focused on education, it branches out far beyond that with a wave of anti-science beliefs such as the anti-vaccine movement becoming more popular.

The most difficult aspect is implementing measures to address the problem that respect every individual's beliefs.
To conclude, the conference theme "Equity in an uneducated world" is reflected in this topic through the exclusion of scientific theories from curricula, which results in students not being equally educated and consequently not being given the same learning opportunities. While it's imperative that we respect every individual's culture and personal beliefs, we cannot neglect the importance of a well-rounded education.

Key Terms and Definitions

Scientific Theory

"systematic ideational structure of broad scope that encompasses a family of empirical (experiential) laws regarding regularities existing in objects and events, both observed and posited. A scientific theory is a structure suggested by these laws and is devised to explain them in a scientifically rational manner."[1]

Curriculum

"A curriculum is an inventory of activities related to the design, organization and planning of an education or training action. It defines learning objectives, content, methods, assessment and material, as well as arrangements for training teachers and trainers."[2]

Ideology

"A set of beliefs or principles, especially one on which a political system, party, or organization is based."[3]

Science Communication

"Science communication is the practice of informing, raising awareness of science-related topics, and also getting involved with audiences that include, at least in part, people from outside the science community."[4]

1 The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica. (2018). Scientific theory. In *Encyclopaedia Britannica*. https://www.britannica.com/science/scientific-theory

2 UNESCO. (2026, October 6). What you need to know about curriculum. https://www.unesco.org/en/curriculum/need-know

3 Cambridge University Press. (n.d.). Ideology. In Cambridge Dictionary. Retrieved October 28, 2026, from https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/ideology

4 Science Europe. (n.d.). Science communication. https://scienceeurope.org/our-priorities/science-communication/

Intelligent Design

"Intelligent design (ID**)**, argument intended to demonstrate that living organisms were created in more or less their present forms by an 'intelligent designer'."[5]

Creationism

"a doctrine or theory holding that matter, the various forms of life, and the world were created by God out of nothing and usually in the way described in Genesis."[6]

Background Information

Historical Development of Scientific Theories in Curricula

Science is a constantly evolving field and, therefore, the way it is taught is consistently changing globally. But it can be difficult to create a national curriculum which the entirety of the population supports and acknowledges.

In the United States, since the late 19th century, there have been continuous efforts to support science programmes and fight for the objective pursuit of truth and understanding in educational curricula. During the first half of the 20th century, social and economic changes, including immigration and the Great Depression, influenced reforms to science education in schools. It continued to be difficult to find a balance between educational programmes that were too difficult and uninteresting and ensuring an equally high-quality education for everyone. Currently, it is very difficult to manage the content in state and local educational curricula in the US as various ideologies and beliefs conflict with the scientific theories taught in schools. Specific examples are examined in Case Studies in Teaching Evolution: The Intersection of Dilemmas in Practice. In some US classrooms, even though evolution has been confirmed to be a core concept for school students to comprehend, it is minimised or ignored and educators may create misconceptions or integrate non-scientific ideologies and beliefs into the curriculum.

In Europe, science is considered of the utmost importance in the curriculum, and teaching methods and curricula aim to be evidence-based and continue to evolve. Science is widely considered important to understanding the world around us in Europe. In parts of East Asia, while there are a

[5] Glick, T. F. (2017). Intelligent design. In *Encyclopaedia Britannica*. https://www.britannica.com/topic/intelligent-design

[6] Merriam-Webster. (n.d.). Creationism. In *Merriam-Webster.com* dictionary. Retrieved October 28, 2026, from https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/creationism

lot of cultural and religious factors, science education is evolving through reforms that emphasise scientific knowledge and skills. Humans have searched for ways to explain the world around them for thousands of years, whether through their culture in ways such as mythology, beliefs, supernatural traditions, or more recently through evidence-based scientific theories and facts.

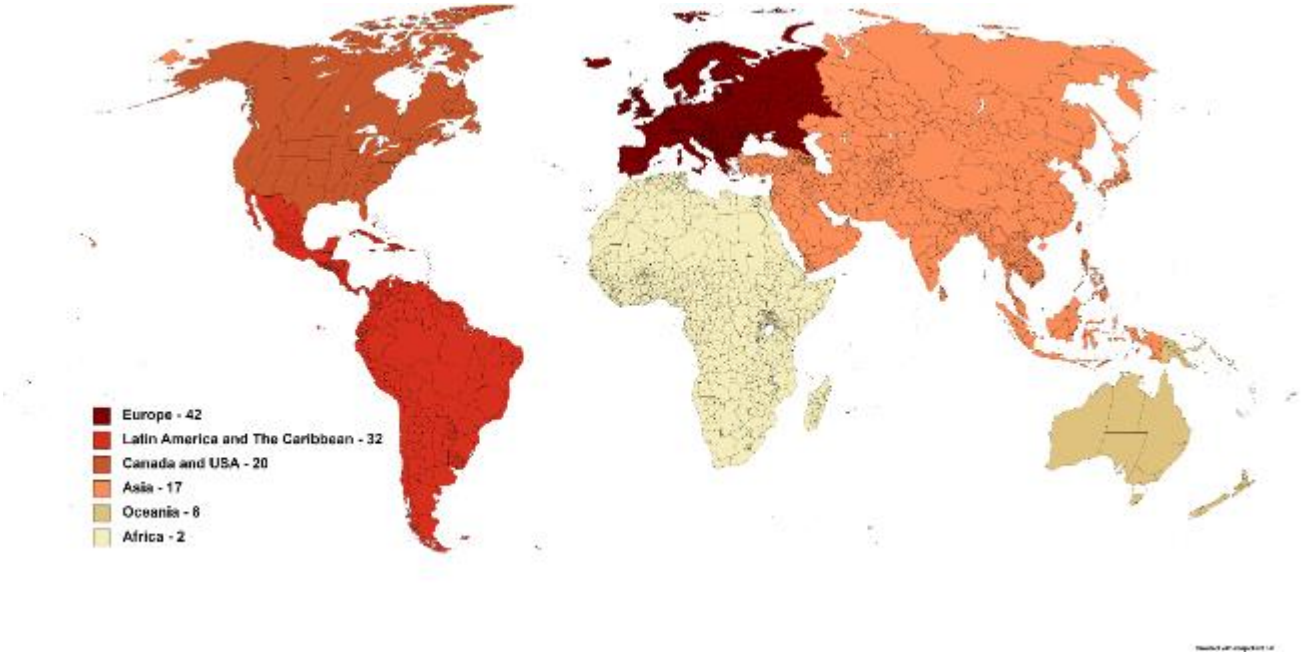


Fig. 1: Science Communication Programmes Identified Worldwide (2023 Study)[7]

Cultural and Ideological Factors That Affect Curricula Including Scientific Theories

Scientific theories may be excluded from or affect curricula for a plethora of reasons. The main factors are religious beliefs, political ideologies, national identity, cultural heritage and social norms.

Religious beliefs often affect issues such as reproductive health and sex education and the theory of evolution. It can be difficult to create a curriculum which teaches and explains both points of view without infringing on either of them. Religious opinions, ideologies and religious leaders can be assets to facilitating a well-rounded education, and it's imperative that the means through which the theories are taught do not disrespect these ideologies. One of the theories that is often excluded from curricula is Darwin's theory of evolution.

[7] Massarani, L., Bray, H., Joubert, M., Ridgway, A., Roche, J., Smyth, F., Stevenson, E., van Dam, F., & de Abreu, W. V. (2023). The distribution of science communication teaching around the globe. *Journal of Science Communication*, *22*(6), Article A05. https://doi.org/10.22323/2.22060205

Political ideologies oftentimes shape educational curricula and reflect socio-political values and influence policies. It's important that scientific theories taught in schools are always evidence- and fact-based regardless of these factors so their integrity is not hindered. National identity, cultural heritage and social norms may also affect curricula both negatively and positively.

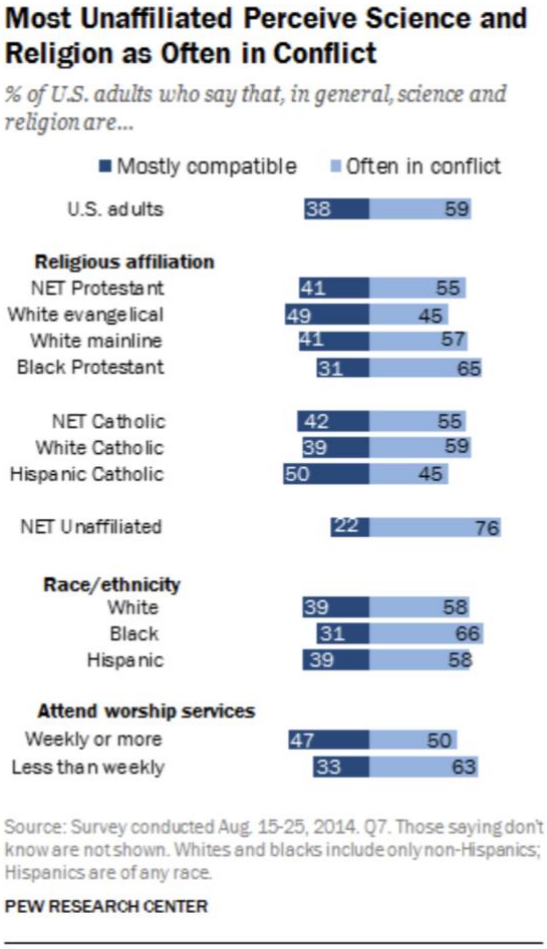


Fig. 2: Perceived Conflict Between Religion and Science in the United States (2014 Survey)[8]

Impact and Challenges in Managing the Issue

Many students have lost the opportunity to gain valuable and necessary information about scientific theories which are somehow tied to our daily lives due to their exclusion from curricula for cultural or religious reasons. It has become clear that this disadvantage can greatly affect individuals in their academic and personal lives.

8 Funk, C. (2015a, October 22). *Perception of conflict between science and religion*. Pew Research Center. https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2015/10/22/perception-of-conflict-between-science-and-religion/

An example that illustrates this is the misinformation that occurred during the COVID-19 pandemic. Misinformation and distrust of scientists and experts contributed to vaccine hesitancy and hindered efforts to control the pandemic. Debate over the severity of climate change has also become an issue as well as the continuation and support of other anti-scientific theories.

The main issue is not creationism as an idea but the danger of creationist beliefs passing for science. This could be catastrophic, especially as it is deeply rooted in educational frameworks, meaning that children from a very young age up until higher levels of education may be severely misinformed. As far as sex education and reproductive health are concerned, misinformation on these topics could be equally damaging to an individual's health and understanding of the world.

It is also increasingly difficult to manage the issue as the balance between respecting personal beliefs and ensuring a worthwhile and complete education is very fragile. Many governments or certain political figures and many individuals support creationist views and every individual's idea of a correct way of educating students is different. While it's important to understand and respect different beliefs and perspectives, there are scientific facts and theories that have become necessary information to coexist with individuals all over the world.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
24 November 1859	On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection was published by Charles Darwin.
21 March 1925	Tennessee's governor signed the Butler Act, which prohibited teaching human evolution in state-funded universities, teacher-training institutions and public schools.
10 December 1948	The Universal Declaration of Human Rights was adopted recognising education as a human right under Article 26.
14 December 1960	UNESCO adopted the Convention against Discrimination in Education.

Date	Description of Event
4 October 2007	Council of Europe Parliamentary Assembly Resolution 1580, entitled The dangers of creationism in education, was adopted as a non-binding document which encourages the separation of beliefs from science especially in education. It also warns against the spread of creationist ideas and the danger they pose to established scientific theories.
25 September 2015	The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) were adopted, including the fourth SDG which promotes inclusive and equitable quality education for everyone.

United States (US)

The United States has long experienced disputes over science education and it has become increasingly difficult to maintain the proper balance between beliefs and scientific evidence. In the past two decades there have been efforts to introduce more creationist ideas in school curricula and alter or exclude specific scientific theories. Topics such as evolution, global warming, the chemical origins of life, DNA and fossil discoveries have been targeted by legislative proposals in some states. In a related public-health debate, an Associated Press investigation reported in October 2025 that over 420 bills targeting vaccines, milk safety and fluoride had been introduced in US states that year. One of the most debated issues is vaccination.

Hours	Human Evolution	General Evolutionary Processes	Creationism or Intelligent Design
Not covered	17%	2%	75%
1–2 hours	35%	9%	18%
3–5 hours	25%	25%	5%
6–10 hours	12%	26%	1%
11–15 hours	5%	18%	1%
16–20 hours	3%	11%	1%
20 hours or more	2%	9%	0%
Total	100%	100%	100%

Fig. 3: Hours Spent Teaching Evolution and Creationism in US High School Biology Classrooms (2007 Survey).[9]

Türkiye

Türkiye reformed its curriculum in 2017, deferring detailed teaching of evolutionary biology to university while retaining concepts such as mutation, selection and adaptation in school biology.

9 Berkman, M. B., Pacheco, J. S., & Plutzer, E. (2008). Evolution and creationism in America's classrooms: A national portrait. *PLoS Biology*, *6*(5), Article e124. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pbio.0060124

The reforms also included religious content on jihad, which the education minister said was intended to correct misconceptions. These changes drew criticism from scientists and educators .

National Center for Science Education (NCSE)

The NCSE promotes and defends accurate and effective science education to ensure that everyone has access to and engages with evidence-based science. The NCSE is known to defend the teaching of evolution and climate science in schools, some of the issues which are often excluded from curricula. The organisation also spearheaded the Voices for Evolution Project which collects statements from diverse individuals and organisations in support of teaching evolution in public educational institutions in the United States.

International Council of Associations for Science Education (ICASE)

ICASE is a global organisation established through a UNESCO initiative, which cooperates with other organisations to promote science, technology and education. The organisation aims to increase scientific and technological literacy to achieve sustainable development. Members of ICASE are part of a dynamic network of educators, researchers and professionals who dedicate themselves to promoting science education on an international scale. ICASE's work includes various publications as well as conferences.

UN Documents and International Agreements

UNESCO's Recommendation concerning the Status of Higher-Education Teaching Personnel

The Recommendation was adopted by UNESCO on 11 November 1997 in Paris, France, and is not legally binding. UNESCO recommendations are not subject to ratification, acceptance or approval by Member States. Its implementation depends on action by Member States; its non-binding status does not, by itself, establish that the measure has been ineffective.

International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights

This International Covenant was adopted on 16 December 1966 by General Assembly resolution 2200A (XXI), although it entered into force on 3 January 1976. Article 13 recognises the right to education for all to create a free and equitable society and strengthen human rights and fundamental freedoms. Article 15 also recognises the right to enjoy the benefits and applications of scientific progress. Unlike non-binding recommendations, the Covenant creates legal obligations for its States parties, although implementation and enforcement remain challenging.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

Council of Europe Parliamentary Assembly Resolution 1580 (The dangers of creationism in education)

This resolution was adopted in 2007 and highlights the importance of countering tendencies to pass off beliefs and ideologies as science. It promotes the coexistence of science and belief but warns against the effect creationism and present-day creationists could have on education.

Project 2061

Project 2061 was established as a long-term initiative focused on research and development with the goal of increasing literacy in science, mathematics and technology in the United States. Educators, policymakers and researchers can use the project's tools and services to make critical and permanent changes to the United States educational system. The project has also proposed certain science learning goals to act as a foundation for both state curricula and national educational standards. The project also developed assessments to help analyse students' understanding of science learning goals and diagnose any learning or conceptual difficulties.

Possible Solutions

Independent National Curriculum Review Panels

The solution proposed would encourage the creation of review panels consisting of unbiased and carefully selected panellists such as scientists, educators and other experts to evaluate decisions taken by governments to reform curricula. The panel would also consist of other experts such as UN specialists or NGO members as well. These panels would also ensure that science curricula are evidence-based without dismissing creationist beliefs as a negative idea.

Scientific Literacy Programmes

Scientific literacy programmes would teach students about the process required to develop a scientifically accurate and evidence-based theory. The programmes would also include a rotation of visiting professors, scientists and religious leaders, among others, to create and subsequently maintain the balance between culture and ideologies and science. They could address both adults in every community and students at colleges and universities, as well as elementary to high school students. Gradually, the programme would be integrated into the everyday curriculum to facilitate the learning process.

Further reading (optional)

The following section contains articles and reports, some of which are not directly related to the topic but are useful in understanding the social context.

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